HISTORY OF KERALAM UPTO THE 12TH CENTURY

കേരള ചരിത്രം 12-ാം നൂറ്റാണ്ട് വരെ

Module I

Keralam: Landscape and Environment (കേരളം: ഭൂപ്രകൃതിയും പരിസ്ഥിതിയും)

Important Exam Points & Key Highlights

- **Geography:** Kerala is a scalene triangle-shaped narrow strip (38,863 sq.km) bounded by the Western Ghats (East) and Arabian Sea (West) [cite: 1].
- **5 Physical Regions:** Mountain peaks (>1,800m), Highlands (600-1,800m), Midlands (300-600m), Lowlands (10-300m), Coastal plains/lagoons (<10m) [cite: 1].
- **Western Ghats (Sahyadri / പശ്ചിമഘട്ടം):** Controls South India's climate [cite: 1]. Contains plateaus (Wayanad, Nelliampathi, Munnar, Greater Periyar) [cite: 1]. Highest peak: **Anamudi** [cite: 1]. Acts as a natural barrier resisting external attacks until the 18th century [cite: 1].
- **Major Passes (ചുരങ്ങൾ):** Palghat Gap (80km long, 30km wide), Gudalur, Ariankavu, Bodinayakkannur [cite: 1]. The **Palakkad Pass** was crucial for Chera expansion and Mysorean attacks (Hyder Ali built a fort in 1776) [cite: 1].
- **Rivers (നദികൾ):** 44 rivers (41 west-flowing, 3 east-flowing) [cite: 1]. Major ones: Periyar (longest, 244 km), Bharathapuzha (209 km), Chaliyar, Pamba, Chalakudi [cite: 1].
- **Backwaters (കായലുകൾ):** Interconnected coastal lagoons used for navigation [cite: 1]. **Vembanad** (largest, 83 km) and **Asthamudi** (8 branches) [cite: 1].
- **Soil Types:** 10 groups [cite: 1]. **Lateritic** is most predominant [cite: 1]. **Acid Saline soils** (Kayal, Karapadam, Kari) are unique to the Kuttanad region (below sea level) [cite: 1].
- **Climate & Monsoon (കാലവർഷം):** Southwest monsoon (June-Sept, *Edavappathi*) brings >60% rain [cite: 1]. Northeast monsoon (Oct-Dec, *Thulavarsham*) [cite: 1]. Avg rainfall ~300 cm [cite: 1].
- **Flora, Fauna & Trade:** Exports included elephants, peacocks, ivory, teak (found in ruins of Ur), and spices like pepper (**Black Gold**), cardamom, and cinnamon, attracting Romans, Chinese, Arabs, and later Europeans (Portuguese, Dutch, French, English) [cite: 1].

Model Questions & Answers (Pages 14-15)

Comprehensive answers covering Section A, B, and C requirements based on the provided text.

Section A: Short Answer Concepts (3 Marks)

1. Geomorphology

Geomorphology refers to the physical features of the earth [cite: 1]. Kerala is divided into 5 main physical regions based on physiography and slope: mountain peaks (above 1800m), highlands (600-1800m), midlands (300-600m), lowlands (10-300m), and coastal plains and lagoons (below 10m) [cite: 1].

2. Western Ghats (പശ്ചിമഘട്ടം)

Known in ancient texts as Sahyadri, the Western Ghats form the eastern boundary of Kerala with an average height of 5000 feet [cite: 1]. They control the climate by capturing the southwest monsoon and acted as a natural protective barrier against land invasions up to the 18th century [cite: 1].

3. Mountain pass (ചുരം)

Passes are natural breaks in the continuous mountain range of the Western Ghats [cite: 1]. The most prominent is the Palghat Gap (30km wide) [cite: 1]. Others include Bodinayakkannur, Gudalur, and Ariankavu [cite: 1]. They historically served as vital corridors for trade, cultural exchange, and military invasions [cite: 1].

4. Backwaters (കായലുകൾ)

Backwaters are chains of brackish or hypersaline water bodies running parallel to the Kerala coast, separated from the sea by sandy barriers [cite: 1]. Most are interconnected by canals for navigation [cite: 1]. Notable examples include Vembanad Lake and Asthamudi Kayal [cite: 1].

5. Estuaries

Estuaries in Kerala are partially mixed systems where perennial rivers discharge into coastal lagoons [cite: 1]. During monsoons, they overflow into the sea carrying sediments, while in summer, seawater penetrates inland [cite: 1]. The largest is Vembanad (fed by 6 rivers) [cite: 1].

6. Monsoon (മൺസൂൺ)

Kerala has two monsoons: the southwest monsoon (Edavappathi, June-Sept) yielding over 60% of precipitation, and the northeast monsoon (Thulavarsham, Oct-Dec) [cite: 1]. The state receives an annual average rainfall of about 300 cm, deeply influencing agriculture [cite: 1].

7. Laterite soil

The most predominant soil in Kerala, reddish-brown to yellowish-red in color [cite: 1]. Though generally poor in available nitrogen, phosphorus, and potash, it is deep, well-drained, and supports crops like coconut, tapioca, rubber, cashew, and pepper [cite: 1].

8. Biodiversity

Kerala's unique climate supports rich flora and fauna [cite: 1]. Historically, aromatic plants (pepper, cardamom, cinnamon) and fauna (elephants, peacocks, ivory) were heavily exported [cite: 1]. Teak wood was famed globally, discovered even in the ruins of Ur [cite: 1].

9. Midland

The midland region covers 8.44% of Kerala's area, sitting between 300 and 600 meters above sea level [cite: 1]. It consists of gently rolling western edges of the highlands, featuring laterite-covered rocky spurs and deep valleys that merge with the lowlands [cite: 1].

10. High ranges

Comprising the mountain peaks (>1800m) and highlands (600-1800m) of the Western Ghats [cite: 1]. This region includes elevated plateaus like Munnar (1500-2000m) and Greater Periyar [cite: 1]. It makes up roughly 21% of the state's total area [cite: 1].

Section B & C: Analytical & Essay Questions (6 & 10 Marks)

Note: Overlapping themes in Sections B and C have been consolidated into comprehensive answers suitable for both short essays (6 marks) and detailed evaluations (10 marks).

11 & 21. Keralam as a distinct ecological/geographical region.

Kerala is uniquely geographically isolated, forming a distinct ecological region [cite: 1]. It is a narrow strip shaped like a scalene triangle (38,863 sq.km) [cite: 1]. Its physical boundaries completely define its character: the towering Western Ghats to the east act as a formidable wall, and the Arabian Sea to the west opens it to the world [cite: 1].

Internally, the region transitions rapidly through five distinct physical zones: mountain peaks, highlands, midlands, lowlands, and coastal plains [cite: 1]. This steep variation in relief over just 11 to 124 kilometers of width creates diverse micro-climates, supporting a dense network of 44 rivers and specialized ecosystems like the below-sea-level Kuttanad region [cite: 1].

12 & 22. Ecological and economic significance of the Western Ghats.

Ecological: Known as *Sahyadri*, the Western Ghats dictate the region's climate by intercepting the southwest monsoon winds, causing heavy rainfall on the western slopes (averaging 300cm annually) [cite: 1]. This sustains the rivers and supports dense tropical biodiversity [cite: 1].

Economic & Historical: Historically, the 5000-foot-high ranges acted as a natural fortress, preventing landward invasions from other parts of India until the 18th century [cite: 1]. Economically, the plateaus (Wayanad, Munnar, Periyar) support high-altitude agriculture, while the forests provide immensely valuable timber (teak) and spices (cardamom, pepper) that fueled Kerala's ancient global trade network [cite: 1].

13 & 23. The role of mountain passes in Keralam's history.

Despite the Western Ghats acting as a barrier, natural breaks called passes facilitated vital interactions [cite: 1].
* **Palghat Gap:** The largest (80km long, 30km wide) [cite: 1]. It was the primary corridor for cultural and commercial exchange between the Malabar coast and peninsular India [cite: 1]. The Cheras used it to expand into Kongu Nadu, and it allowed the 18th-century Mysorean invasion by Hyder Ali, who built a fort there in 1776 [cite: 1].
* **Other Passes:** Bodinayakkannur, Gudalur, and Ariankavu (Punalur region) [cite: 1]. These narrower, higher-elevation passes connected specific regions (e.g., Idukki to Madurai, Quilon to Tirunelveli), enabling trade routes for hill produce and spices [cite: 1].

14 & 24. Influence of the Indian Ocean on climate, trade, and historical development.

The Arabian Sea coastline (approx 560 km) is the base of Kerala's geographical triangle and its gateway to the world [cite: 1].
* **Trade:** Since ancient times, monsoon winds guided Roman, Arab, and Chinese merchant ships to ancient ports like Muziris, Tindis, and Nelkinda to trade for "black gold" (pepper) and pearls [cite: 1].
* **Cultural & Political:** The coast brought the world's principal religions (Judaism, Christianity, Islam) to Kerala [cite: 1]. Later, it became the entry point for European colonial powers (Portuguese, Dutch, French, English) who established forts at Anjengo, Thalassery, and Kannur to monopolize the spice trade [cite: 1].
* **Economy/Climate:** The sea moderates the coastal temperatures (25-32°C) and supports a thriving fishing and salt-making industry, while driving the vital monsoon weather systems [cite: 1].

15 & 25. River systems of Keralam and their role.

Kerala is drained by 44 mostly short, fast-flowing rivers (41 flowing west into the Arabian Sea/ backwaters, 3 flowing east) [cite: 1]. Because of steep gradients, they are in a youthful stage, forming cascades in the upper reaches [cite: 1].
* **Major Rivers:** Periyar (longest, 244 km), Bharathapuzha (209 km), Chaliyar, Pamba, and Chalakudi [cite: 1]. Together, these five drain 40% of Kerala [cite: 1].
* **Impact:** Rivers dictated settlement patterns. Their fertile floodplains and alluvial terraces supported agriculture [cite: 1]. They provided internal navigation, deposited placer gold (Chaliyar), and today support massive reservoirs (Idukki, Malampuzha) crucial for the state's water and power infrastructure [cite: 1].

16 & 26. Soil types and agricultural implications.

Kerala's soils are classified into 10 broad groups, heavily influencing regional agriculture [cite: 1]:
* **Lateritic Soil:** The most predominant [cite: 1]. Though low in nutrients, its depth and drainage make it ideal for cash crops like rubber, coconut, cashew, and pepper [cite: 1].
* **Acid Saline Soils:** Found exclusively in the Kuttanad region (below sea level), comprising Kayal, Karapadam, and Kari soils [cite: 1]. Despite being acidic, water-logged, and prone to saline ingress, they are uniquely managed for specialized paddy cultivation [cite: 1].
* **Riverine/Coastal Alluvial:** Found along riverbanks and coasts, highly fertile and suited for paddy, coconut, and arecanut [cite: 1].
* **Forest Loams:** Found in the eastern Ghats over crystalline rocks, enriched by vegetation canopy, supporting dense forests and plantations [cite: 1].

17, 18, 19, 20. Backwaters, Monsoons, and Flora/Fauna (Consolidated)

Backwaters (Kayals): Systems like Vembanad (83 km long) and Asthamudi (eight braids) act as economic lifelines [cite: 1]. They support inland navigation, fishing, and agriculture (like Kuttanad's below-sea-level farming) while absorbing monsoon overflow [cite: 1].
Climate & Agriculture: The tropical, humid climate driven by the Southwest (Edavappathi) and Northeast (Thulavarsham) monsoons provides the ~300cm of rain necessary for water-intensive crops like paddy and humidity-loving spices [cite: 1].
Flora & Fauna: The state's biodiversity directly shaped its history [cite: 1]. The global demand for Kerala's flora (pepper, cinnamon, teak) and fauna (elephants, ivory, peacocks) brought continuous foreign interaction [cite: 1].